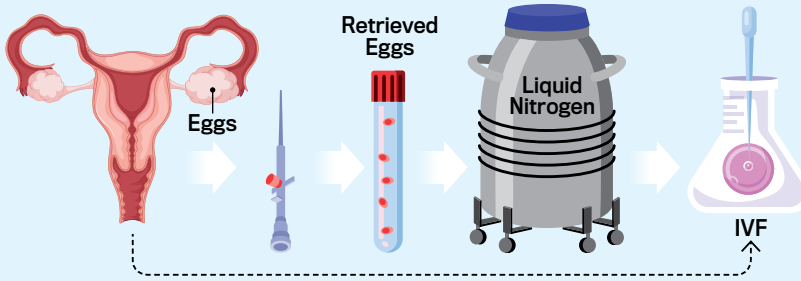
PRESERVATION INSTINCT

The mechanics of egg-freezing



1 The process involves the hormonal stimulation of the ovaries, causing them to release more than one egg in a cycle

2 The eggs are then retrieved and frozen in liquid nitrogen

3 When required, an egg is thawed and combined with sperm in an IVF lab and the fertilised embryo then transplanted into the uterus

₹1.6-2.5 LAKH

The cost of egg-freezing in India. Followed by Rs 10,000-25,000 a month for storage. The Assisted Reproductive Technology (Regulation) Act, 2021, stipulates that eggs can be stored for up to 10 years, after which they are destroyed or donated for research



- Frozen eggs require IVF to achieve pregnancy. The health of the egg at the time of freezing is thus important. Age, lifestyle, weight and overall health determine that
- Couples also have the option to freeze fertilised eggs, in which case the IVF process is done first and then the embryo is frozen. In this method, both partners have a legal right over it, whereas in egg-freezing, only the woman does



> **"A person can opt for embryo-freezing if they're married rather than egg-freezing. With the latter, there's less certainty about whether the partner's sperm will be healthy"**
>
> **DR SURVEEN GHUMMAN SINDHU**
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weren't able to have healthy eggs," says Dr Preeti Rastogi, director of the Institute of Obstetrics and Gynaecology at Medanta in Gurugram. "For example, if you had to have chemotherapy, radiation or some surgery, then the eggs were frozen to retain the option of childbirth later." However, with a growing number of women focusing on their career before choosing to become mothers, egg freezing offers them a way out. While there is no comprehensive data that captures the trend nationally, the Indian Society for Assisted Reproduction (ISAR) as well as several leading IVF clinics, such as the Bloom IVF Group, Fortis La Femme and Apollo Fertility, claim there is a 10-25 per cent rise in egg-freezing procedures compared to the years before Covid-19. They say most women opting for it are between the ages of 30 and 35 years and cite professional reasons for wanting to delay pregnancy.

The procedure itself is quite intricate. It involves the hormonal stimulation of the ovaries, which leads them to release more than one egg per cycle. The egg is then retrieved and frozen in liquid nitrogen to preserve it until the donor wishes to opt for pregnancy. At this point, the egg is thawed, combined with sperm in an IVF (in-vitro fertilization) lab and the fertilised embryo transplanted into the uterus. Currently, the procedure in India can cost anywhere between Rs 1.6 lakh and Rs 2.5 lakh, and then, Rs 10,000-Rs 20,000 a month for storage. Eggs can be stored for up to 10 years, after which they are destroyed or donated for research, per the guidelines under Assisted Reproductive Technology (Regulation) Act, 2021.

The Threat of Infertility

Professional growth apart, the fear of infertility is another reason that is driving the trend of freezing one's eggs. Many women are realising that by the time they are ready for children, it may be too late. Delhi-based journalist Sujata Sen (name changed), 36, says she has heard so many stories of difficult late pregnancies that she has been pushing her younger sister to freeze her eggs before she turns 30. "I don't want her to live in regret," says Sen.

Infertility is indeed a widespread concern in India. The country has a population of as many as 27.5 million infertile people, including men and women, according to ISAR. The 2019 *United Nation's World Population Prospects* estimated that the fertility rate of Indians (the number of children born to a woman) plunged by more than 50 per cent between 1975 and 2020. Dr Priya Selvaraj, a noted gynaecologist from Tamil Nadu who performed the first frozen oocyte pregnancy in India in 2008, blames rising infertility on lifestyle issues, such as stress, eating habits and lack of physical fitness. "Age is also an important predictor of fertility prospects in Indian women," she says. "And that's because, with a mean of 46.6 years, we tend to reach menopause earlier than our western counterparts."

Research bears this out. Smoking, for example, has been linked with a negative impact on ovarian function since the 1990s. In 1996, a study in the journal *Ob-*